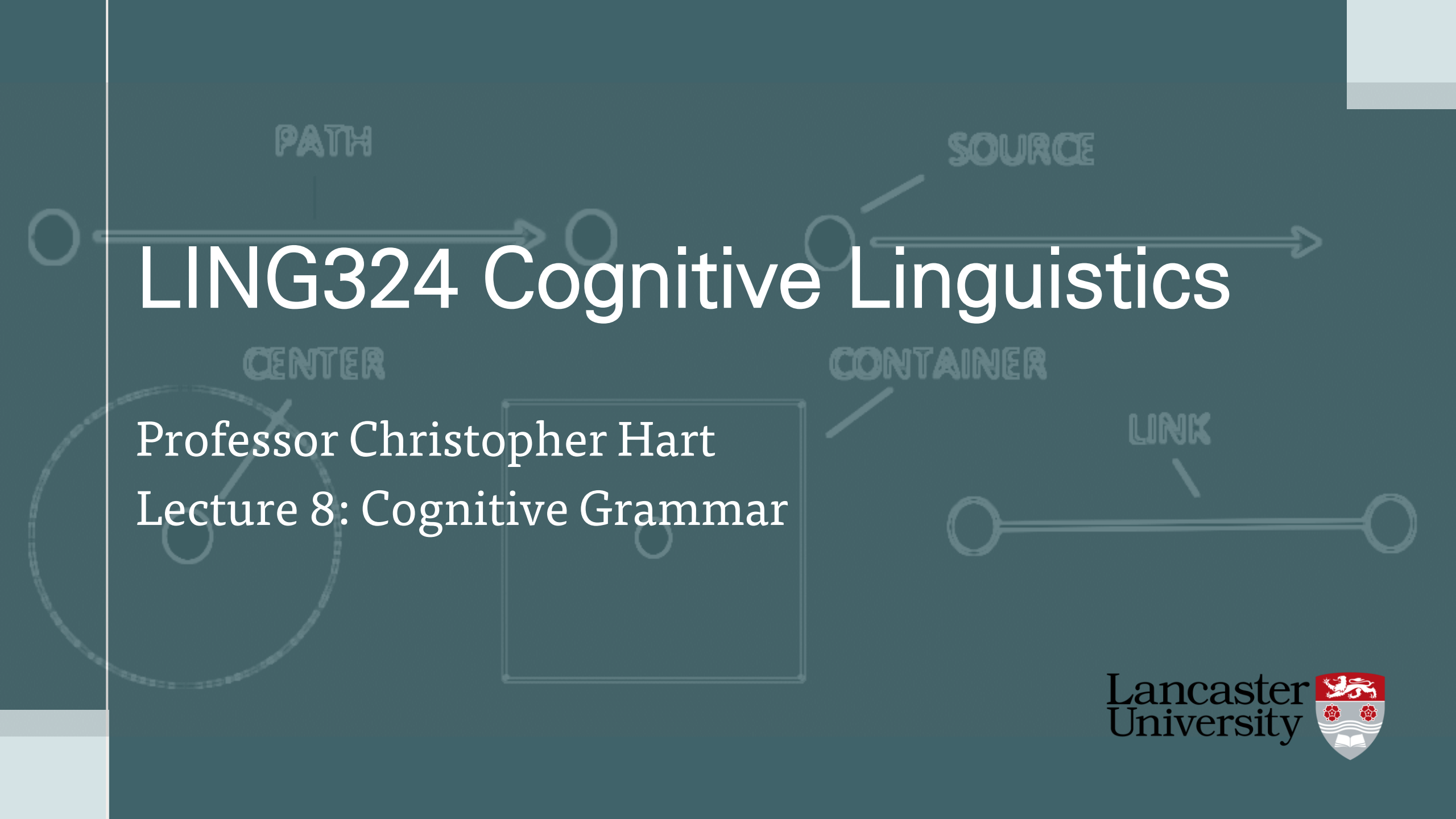




LING324 Cognitive Linguistics

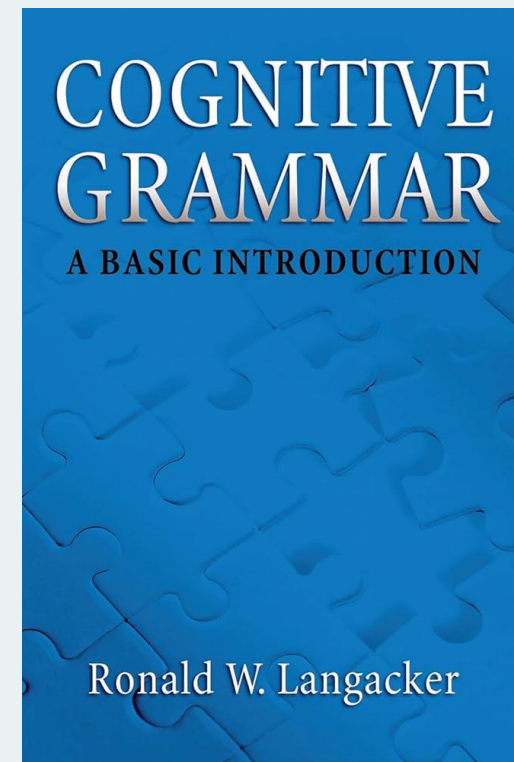
Professor Christopher Hart
Lecture 8: Cognitive Grammar

Overview

- Introduction
- Words and Rules
- Symbolic Assemblies, again
- Conceptual Content
- Construal
- Word Classes
- Sub-Classes
- Tense and Aspect
- Clause structure
- Modality
- Subjective vs. Objective Construal

Introduction

- Model of linguistic description developed by Langacker (e.g. 1987, 1991, 2008)
- Dually grounded in cognition and social interaction – cognitive and usage-based
- Psychologically plausible
 - Structures and processes of language reflect general cognitive processes and are fully describable in terms of those processes
 - Conceptual/perceptual analogues
- Meaning as feature of all linguistic structures
- Complex, philosophical but beautiful!



Neither basic nor introductory!

Words and Rules

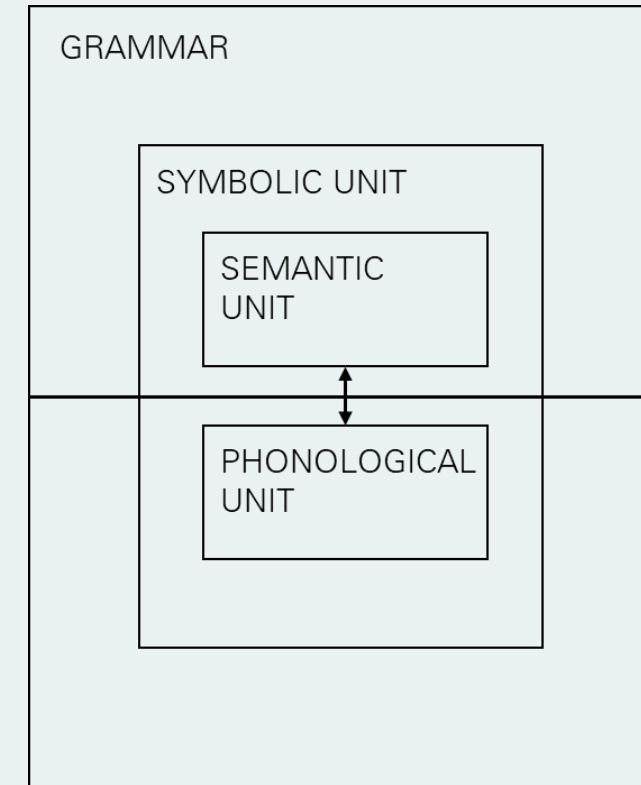
- Two distinct systems:
 - **Lexicon** - words
 - **Grammar** - symbol-manipulating rules governing inflection and combination of words
- Sentences built up from words
- Meaning of a sentence computed *ad hoc* to recover thought expressed

Inside everyone's head there is a finite algorithm with the ability to generate an infinite number of potential sentences, each corresponding to a distinct thought. The meaning of a sentence is computed from the meanings of the individual words and the way they are arranged. (Pinker 1998: 220)



Symbolic Assemblies

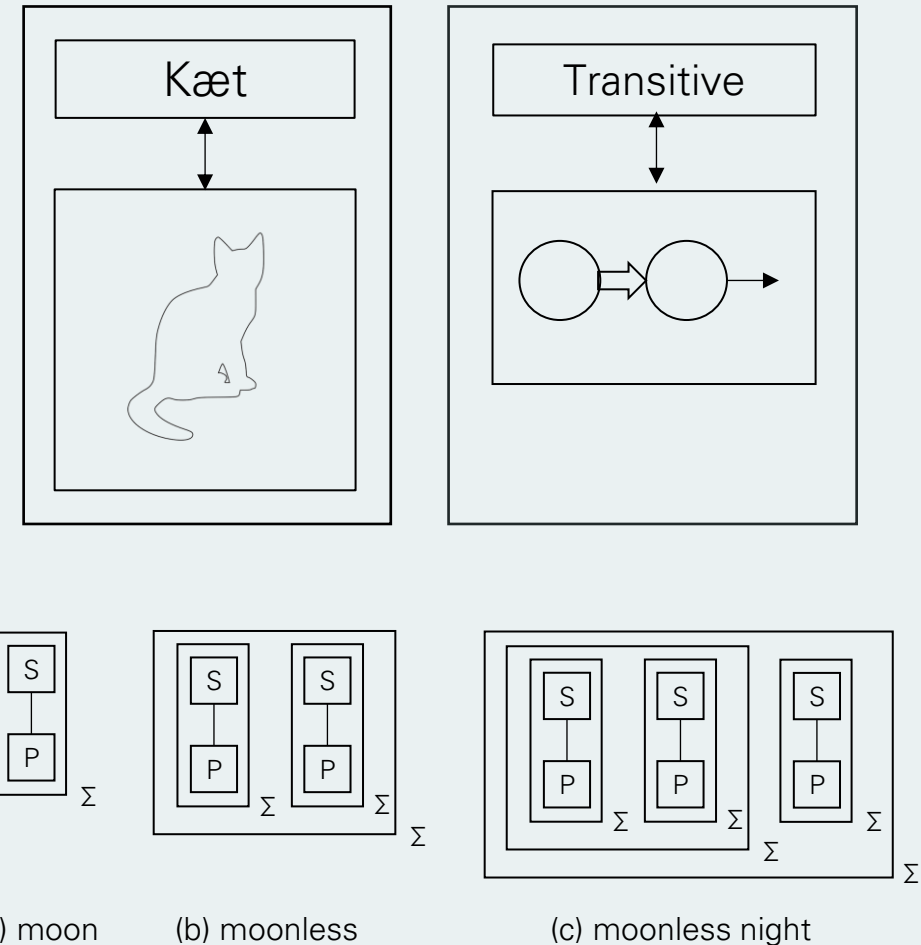
- One system: continuity of grammar and lexicon
- Language consists of system of form-meaning pairings or **symbolic assemblies**
- Theoretical austerity where just three elements required:
 - **Semantic structures** (conceptualisations)
 - **Phonological structures** (sounds, gestures, orthographic representations)
 - **Symbolic structures** (in which semantic and phonological structures conventionally linked)



Grammatical structures do not constitute an autonomous formal system or level of representation: they are claimed instead to be inherently symbolic, providing for the structuring and conventional symbolization of conceptual content. Lexicon, morphology, and syntax form a continuum of symbolic units, divided only arbitrarily into separate components. (Langacker 2002: 1)

Symbolic Assemblies

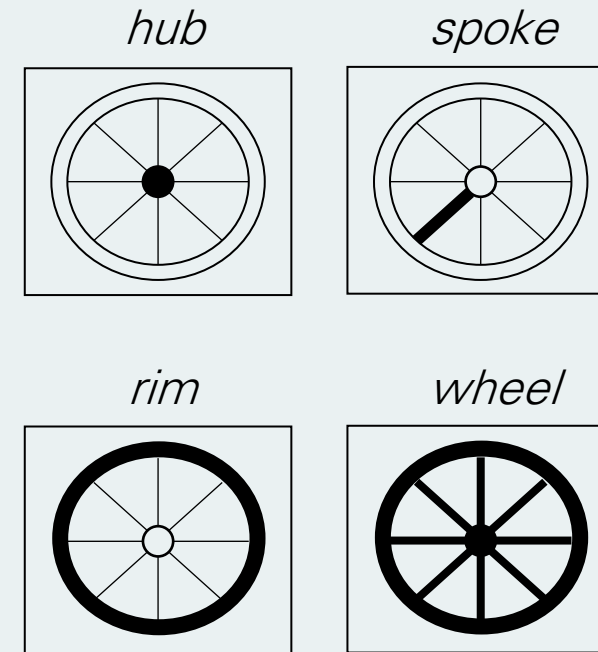
- Inventory vs. derivational system: grammatical units stored in same way as lexical units
 - **Unit** = “thoroughly mastered structure, that is, one that a speaker can activate as a preassembled whole without attending the specifics of its internal structure” (Langacker 1986: 16)
- Grammatical forms themselves meaningful by virtue of semantic structures paired with
- Distinction between lexical and grammatical units artificial
- Difference only in degree of **specificity-schematicity** and **complexity**



(Langacker 2008: 15-16)

Conceptual Content

- Imagistic rather than propositional
- Meaning of a linguistic expression consists in **profile/base** relation
 - **Base** = conceptual content falling within general locus of viewing attention (**immediate scope**)
 - **Profile** = specific portion of conceptual content standing in **focus** relative to base
 - **Domain vs designation**

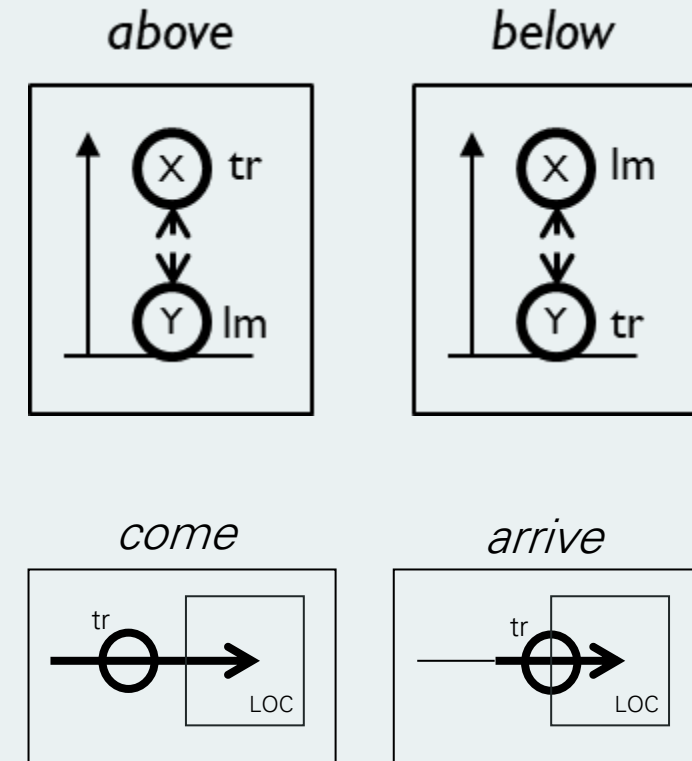


(Langacker 2008: 67)

The first dimension of imagery, observed in every linguistic predication, is the imposition of a "profile" on a "base". (Langacker 1986: 6)

Conceptual Content

- Linguistic expressions profile **things** and **relationships**
 - Nominal vs. relational predication
- When relationship profiled, varying degrees of prominence conferred on participants by Subject/Object status
 - Trajector (tr) vs. landmark (lm)
 - (a) The light is above the table
 - (b) The table is below the light

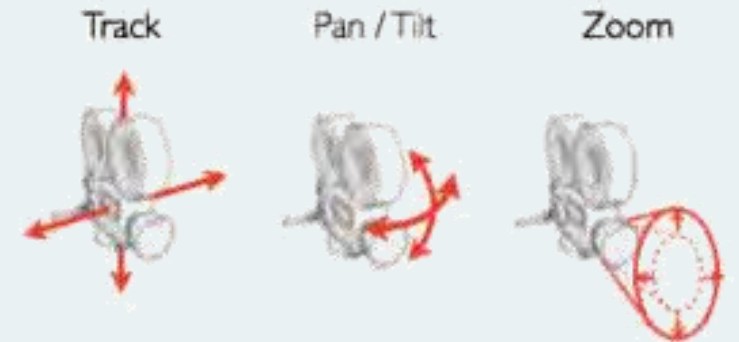


(Langacker 2008: 69-71)

Construal

- **Focus and prominence** (inc. profiling and tr/lm alignment) two dimensions of **construal**
 - “our manifest ability to conceive and portray the same situation in alternate ways” (Langacker 1991: 225)
 - “As part of its conventional semantic value, every symbolic structure construes its content in a certain fashion” (Langacker 2008: 55)

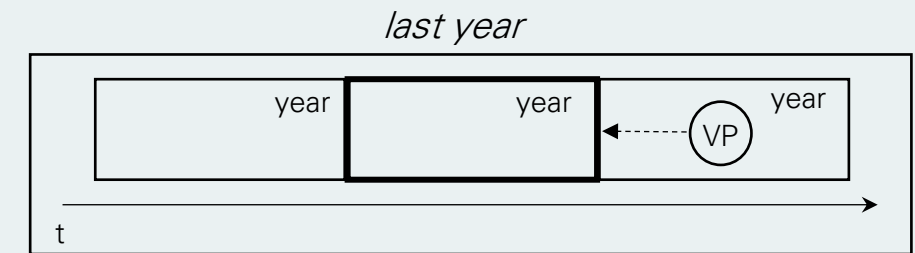
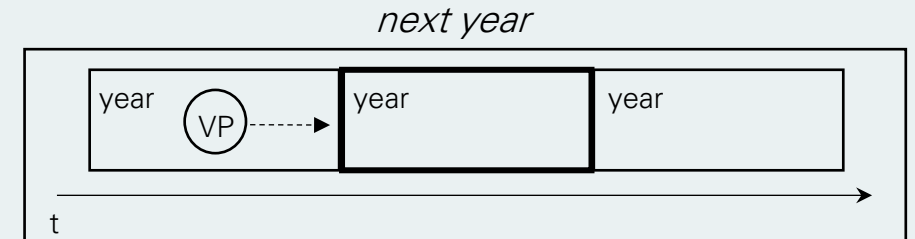
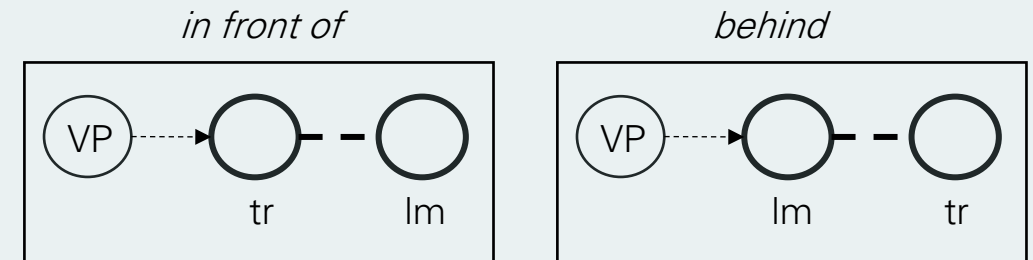
In viewing a scene, what we actually see depends on how closely we examine it, what we choose to look at, which elements we pay most attention to, and where we view it from. (Langacker 2008: 55)



Construal

- Other dimensions: **specificity** and **perspective**
 - Specificity = level of precision and detail at which situation is described
 - Something happened → a person perceived a rodent → a girl saw a porcupine → an alert little girl wearing glasses caught a brief glimpse of a ferocious porcupine with sharp quills
 - Perspective = **viewing arrangement** (vantage point and scanning mode)

The same objective situation can be observed and described from any number of different vantage points ... Many expressions undeniably invoke a vantage point as part of their meaning. (Langacker 2008: 75)



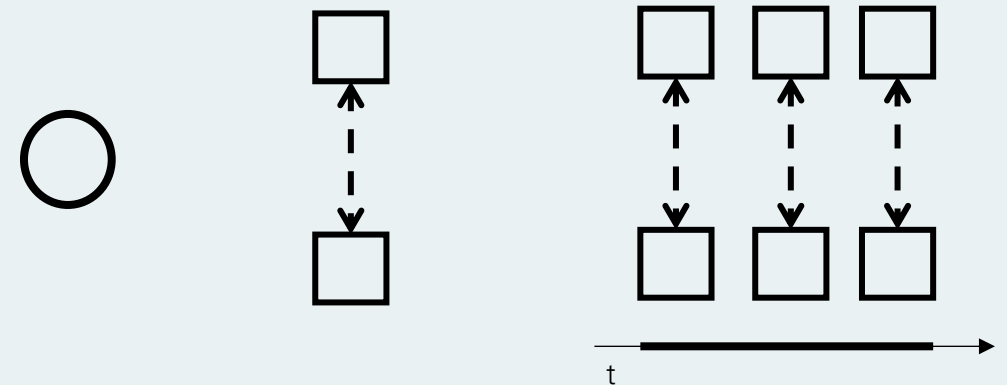
(Langacker 2008: 76-77)

Word Classes

- CG provides semantic characterisation of word classes
 - Universal and fundamental classes (e.g. nouns and verbs)
 - Highly schematic
 - Determined by **profiling**
- **Nominal predications** profile **things**
 - Include nouns
 - Based on **grouping**
 - A conceptually autonomous entity in any domain
- **Relational predications** profile **relationships**
 - **Process** (verbs) vs. **non-processual** relation (adjective, adverb, preposition)

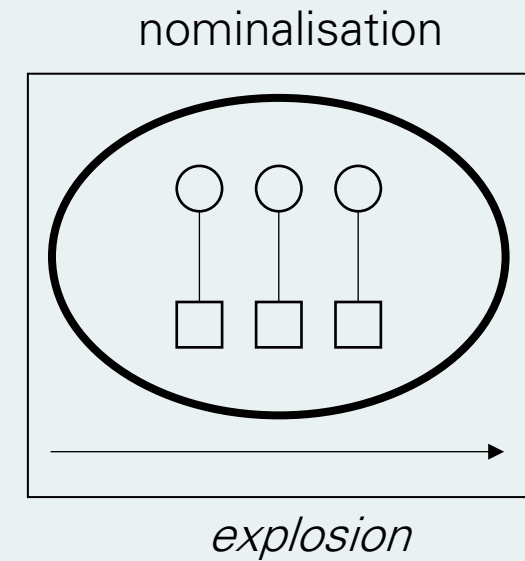
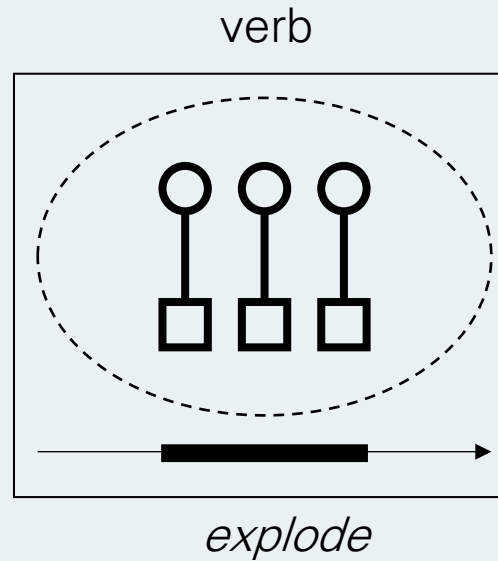
What determines an expression's grammatical category is not its overall conceptual content, but the nature of its profile in particular. (Langacker 2008: 98)

A nominal predication presupposes the interconnections among a set of conceived entities, and profiles the region thus established. On the other hand, a relational predication presupposes a set of entities, and profiles the interconnections among these entities. (Langacker 2002: 74-75)



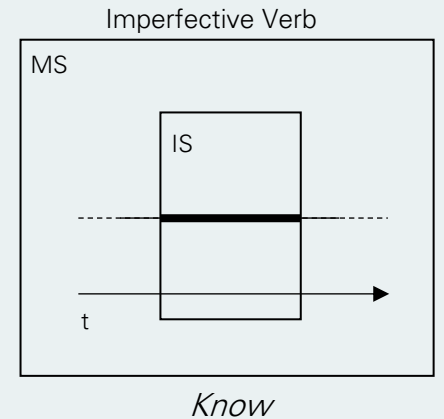
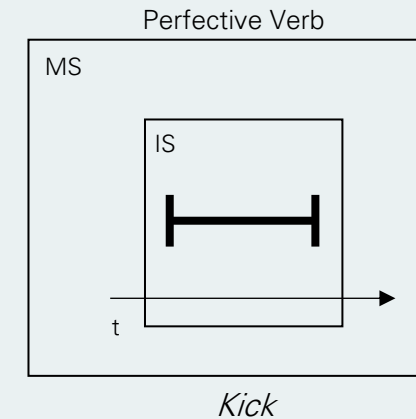
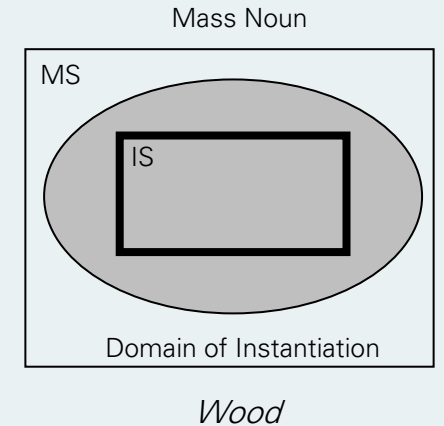
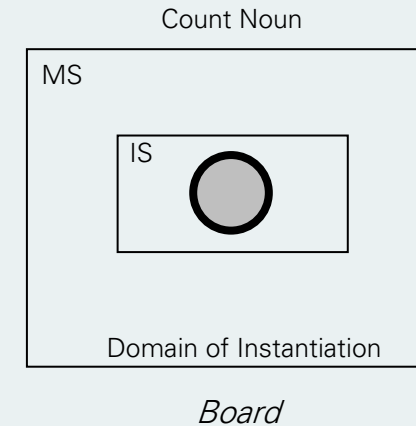
Word Classes

- Nominalisation
 - (a) extract/extraction
 - (b) explode/explosion
- **Reification** of process so construed as thing
- **Sequential** vs. **summary** scanning



Sub-Classes

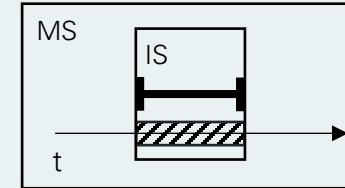
- Count vs. mass nouns
 - **Count:** *diamond, book, cup, cat, country, board, lake, idea, integer, complaint*
 - **Mass:** *gold, paper, meat, water, wood, coal, air, moisture, nonsense, anger, complaining*
- Perfective vs. imperfective verbs
 - **Perfective:** *kick, jump, kill, bite, throw, break, ask, tell*
 - **Imperfective:** *be, have, know, doubt, like, love, live*
- Bounding +/- within immediate scope



Tense

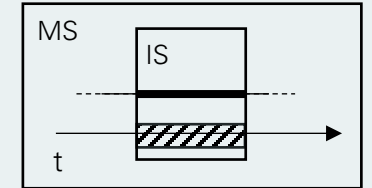
- Tense = **vantage point** in domain of time
 - Present: event and speaking time coincide
 - Past: event occurs prior to speaking time
 - Future: speaking time occurs prior to event
- Interacts with perfective/imperfective verbs
 - English perfective verbs resist simple present tense, except in specialised circumstances such as sports commentary

Present Perfective



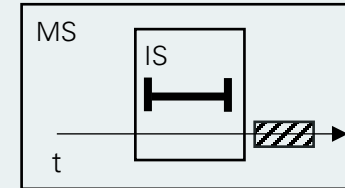
**Wilbur reads the story*

Present Imperfective



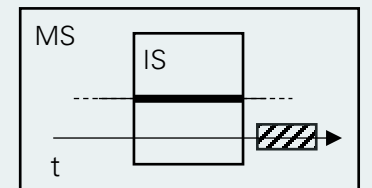
Wilbur knows the story

Past Perfective



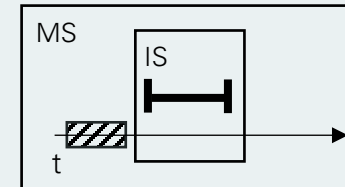
Wilbur read the story

Past Imperfective



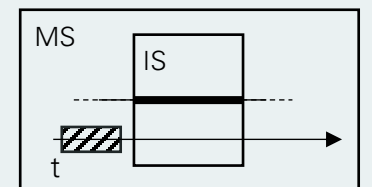
Wilbur knew the story

Future Perfective



Wilbur will read the story

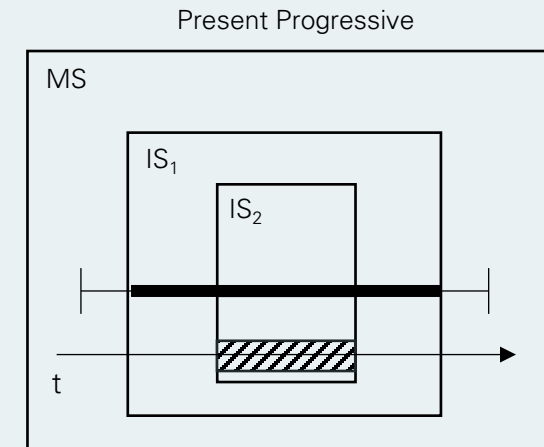
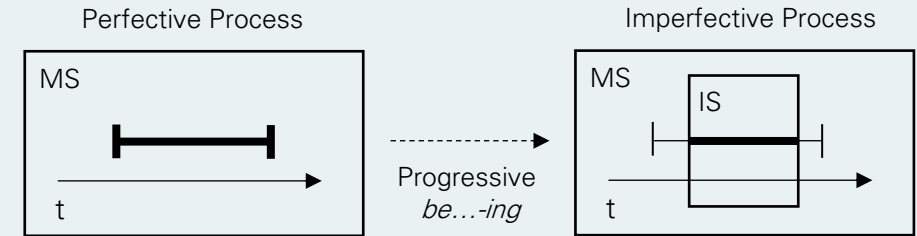
Future Imperfective



Wilbur will know the story

Aspect

- Aspect construes processes as ongoing vs complete:
 - **Progressive**: ongoing
 - **Non-progressive**: complete
- Progressive aspect marked by *be ... -ing*
- Interacts with perfective/imperfective distinction
 - English perfective verbs accept progressive aspect while imperfective verbs do not
 - a) Wilbur is/was reading the story
 - b) *Wilbur is/was knowing the story
 - Progressive aspect converts perfective process into imperfective one by profiling internal portion that excludes endpoints (IS_1)
 - Present tense further delimits profile to portion coincident with speech event (IS_2)



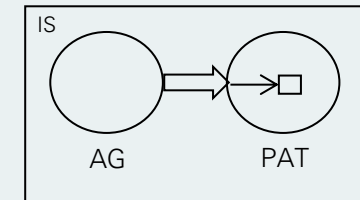
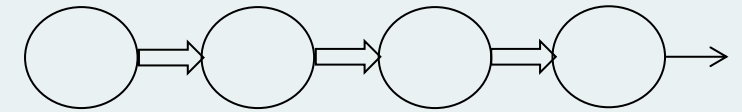
Clause Structure

- Grammar “reflects our basic experience of moving, perceiving, and acting on the world” (Langacker 2008: 4)
- **Conceptual archetypes** – Schematic conceptions of fundamental aspects of experience (action, motion, perception, location)
- Associated with specific clause types
 - Archetypal conceptions provide prototypical semantic values of clause structures
 - Clause structures provide **default coding** for archetypal conceptions
- **Archetypal roles**: agent, patient, instrument, experiencer, mover, zero

Clause Structure

- Archetypal conception associated with **transitive** clause = type of **action chain**
 - **Action chain** = “our conception of objects moving through space and impacting one another through forceful interaction” (Langacker 2008: 355)
 - **Canonical event model** – arguably most typical of all occurrences = two-participant action chain

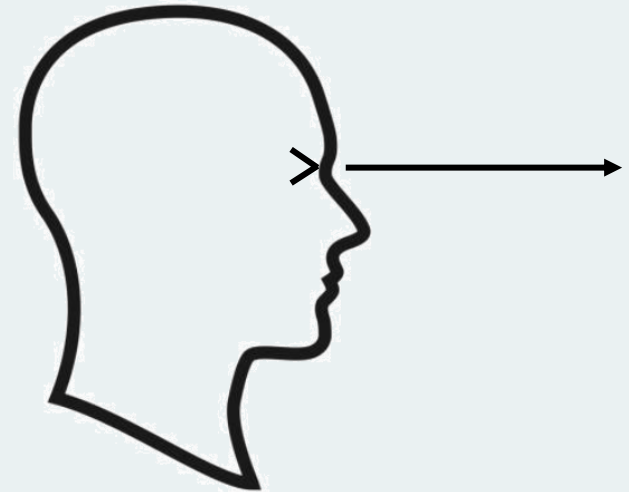
a bounded, forceful event in which an agent (AG) acts on a patient (PAT) to induce a change in state. (Langacker 2008: 357)



- (a) The farmer killed the duckling
- (b) Floyd broke the glass

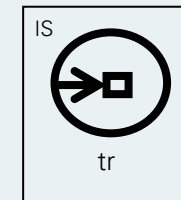
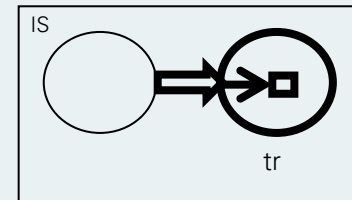
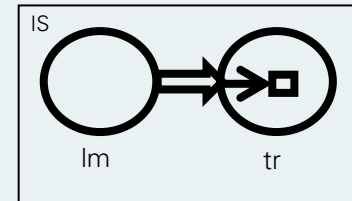
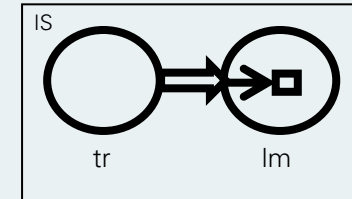
Clause Structure

- Other archetypal occurrences correspond with other clause structures
 - E.g. motion event expressed by intransitive motion verb + locative PP
 - They walked along the river / to the station
- No distinct clause type for mental experiences – also coded by transitive clause
 - I {saw/remembered/imagined} the painting
 - Clause type grounded in physical experience extended to mental experience
 - Motivated by similarity at higher level of abstraction – metaphorical “mental contact”



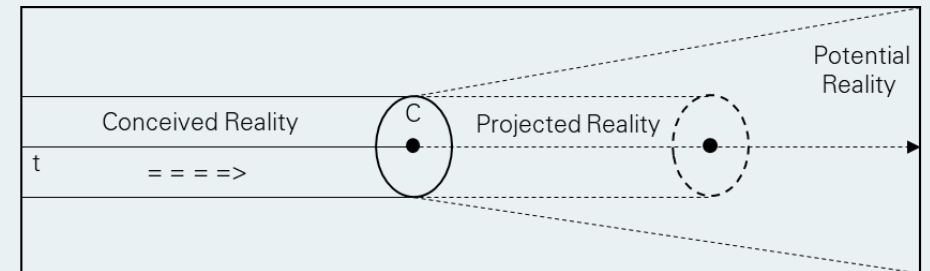
Clause Structure

- Transitive clause **default coding** for events conceived as instantiating canonical event model
 - Full action chain profiled
- Other constructions available to construe archetypal conception in alternate ways
 - **Passive**: the glass was broken by Floyd
 - **Agentless passive**: the glass was broken
 - **Intransitive**: the glass broke



Modality

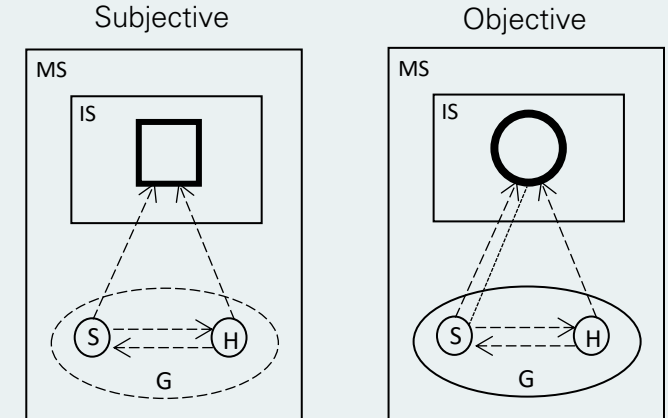
- Analysed in **force-dynamic** terms:
 - **Deontic** senses aimed at **effective control** – to bring about the profiled process
 - **Epistemic** senses aimed at **epistemic control** – to accept the profiled process as real
 - Based on model of **evolving reality**
 - *May* locates the process in **potential reality**, *will* in **projected reality**



(Langacker 2008: 306)

Subjective vs. Objective Construal

- **Subjective** construal
 - **Ground** elements speaker/hearer remain **offstage**
 - Default viewing arrangement
- **Objective** construal
 - Speaker/hearer placed **onstage** within **immediate scope**
 - First-person pronouns (*I, you, we*)
- Intermediate possibilities: *in front of, behind*



(Langacker 2008: 261)

Thank you

Selected References

Langacker, R.W. (1986)

Pinker, S. (1998). Words and rules. *Lingua* 106 (1-4): 219-242.